Reunion of Fires

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Ignition

COL-308001

Ulu: The darkness is like a soft mattress. Sinking under me, folds enveloping me, drawing me ever deeper.

Ulu: In the darkness, I find myself accompanied by unceasing, rhythmic sounds, like the beating of drums and wild cheers, echoing a time when I blazed over red earth.

Ulu: And so I try to find it, that faint sound. It beats with a familiarity and intimacy that entices my flames to sway along with it.

Ulu: And then, a distant light flickers into view. There, I meet her once more.

Ulu: As I follow that light, I see all she experiences.

Ulu: She is only a spark, her glow faint, but burgeoning with curiosity.

Ulu: Day in, day out. She consumes more fuel—everything she sees, touches, and hears makes her burn brighter.

Ulu: How are you? Can you hear me? Shall we continue our unfinished conversation?

Ulu: No response...
Still, I call out, I must call out... to my dearest friend.

Bedroom

Spathodea: ...Hmm? Is someone calling me?

The girl lowers hands that a moment ago fiddled with photos and clippings, lifting her head to scan the room.

Of course, she gains no insights from her efforts.

Spathodea: Hmm... My ears are playing tricks on me again. I thought ... I heard something, but maybe it was nothing...

Spathodea: *sigh* ...

She refocused her energy back to the meticulously collected items before her.

Spathodea: Let's take a look at the picture again... Hmm, it's so different from records of the Uluru Games from other places, but...

Her fantasies of this grand event occupy most of her free time, and even much of the time she should use to finish her homework.

Like this very moment, for example.

???: Are you awake in there, Cookie? Can I come in?

Spathodea: What...? I'm here, I'm awake! I'm just—

Spathodea: So, it wasn't my imagination... For crying out loud... Mummy, I'm coming—

Spathodea stuffed her scattered keepsakes from the desk into a waiting drawer and just as quickly opened her exercise book, in a practiced move.

Then in a brisk series of steps, the little girl runs to the door and turns the knob.

Spathodea: Wh-What is it, Mummy?

Spathodea's Mother: You didn't come down for your milk today, so I guessed my little Cookie must be busy.

Her mother placed the milk at the side of the table, while simultaneously setting a beautiful album down with purposeful intent.

Spathodea's Mother: I've brought a little something for you. I thought I'd give you it along with your milk. Here you go.

Spathodea: Oh my—! It's... all the photos and notes I put together!

Spathodea: I thought Ms. Jones would wait until the last week of term to give it back to me... You beauty... Oh, this is wonderful...

Spathodea's Mother: She knows how important these things are to you, so she packed them in a plastic bag and put them in the top drawer. Look at the cover—your little doodles are as clear as the day you drew them.

Spathodea's Mother: Ms. Jones is a wonderful teacher... But she also told me about what's been going on with you recently... That you've let your mind wander in class, Cookie.

Spathodea: Sorry... I... I didn't mean to...

Spathodea: I just... I just keep thinking about the photos, and...

The guilty child lowers her head and rubs her fists against her eyelids.

Spathodea's Mother: It's okay, we've got all the time in the world.

Her mother placed her palms around the little girl's shoulders and took her into her arms, she sat on the edge of the bed resting her head gently against her daughter's.

Spathodea: It was when... Ms. Jones was talking to us about after-school sports and asking what our favorite events were... I remembered the Uluru Games.

Spathodea: I took out my album to find some events, so I'd have a good answer.

Spathodea: I could've said the branch vault, the water beast steeplechase... They're all so fun, but Ms. Jones said we could only choose our single most favorite event...

Spathodea's Mother: That shouldn't have been a problem for you, my little love. You're always talking about your favorite sport...

Spathodea: Yeah! That's right, Mummy!

Spathodea: It's the one with the stone monster from the stories—Malingee's Harvest!

The girl nods her head twice, the two pigtails behind her dancing like small flames.

But these happy flames flicker for only an instant before she lowers her head again.

Spathodea: My head got so filled with thoughts of playing with Malingee. It was like... like it was all real... Like... the things I see in my dreams...

Spathodea: The red earth of the sports field felt so solid and spongy when I stepped on it... and I could smell the wood burning in the air...

Spathodea: The crowd gathered around the fire—burning wildly and beautifully, like a wild animal... I wanted to reach out to touch its fur...

Spathodea: ...

Spathodea: ...Then Ms. Jones took my hand.

Spathodea opens her eyes, returning from her memories with a pang of regret, her voice timid as a whimpering puppy.

Spathodea: But, I know... I really shouldn't have dozed off in her class...

Spathodea: But the thing is... They say I'm always just daydreaming. They say... I've turned into some kind of drongo all because I love the Uluru Games so much...

Spathodea's Mother: You're a good girl, Cookie.

Her mother sighs softly and adds a gentle rocking to her embrace.

Spathodea's Mother: There's nothing wrong with the things you like and love. Whether it's green crocodiles or even a long gone sports event, they're all your precious treasures.

Spathodea's Mother: Don't ever waver just because someone says things about what you love—and you certainly shouldn't ever feel bad about yourself over such a thing.

Spathodea's Mother: All the things you've collected are proof the Uluru Games happened. It used to be such a grand event, and no one knows what the future holds—

The mother lifts the child's soft round face, wipes away her tears, and kissed her cheek with tender affection.

Spathodea's Mother: Maybe someday in the future, your Uluru Games will return. the same way they disappeared, maybe they'll... suddenly reappear.

Spathodea: Do you... really think so, Mummy?

She's not wrong. No one knows what the future will bring.

More than that, it can feel impossible to crush the dreams of a child.

Spathodea's Mother: Of course, we always need something to look forward to in life, Cookie.

Spathodea's Mother: But... before that happens, you have to promise me something.

A tone of uncertainty lingers in the air as the topic turns, and the mother smiles ever so slightly.

Spathodea's Mother: When you're in school, try to focus on your classes, okay?

Spathodea: Of course, Mummy! I'll pay attention to class in future! I swear on... a whole week's worth of fairy cakes!

The embarrassed child rubs her face as she ardently swore to prove herself.

Then, immediately after, as though only just remembering something, she lifts her head again.

Spathodea: Oh... by the way, Mummy, I want to try the after-school sports club! It's the one Ms. Jones mentioned. Can I go?

Spathodea's Mother: Ms. Jones had a word with me about that, too. Of course, you can go—a bit of exercise would do you a world of good.

Spathodea's Mother: But... your school doesn't have a Malingee's Harvest course, Cookie. They need to consider the differences between arcanists and mankind, and hold activities that are safe for everyone.

Spathodea: Yes... I know. It's okay, Mummy.

Spathodea breaks free from her mother's embrace, stands up straight, and shakes out her arms.

Spathodea: I've made up my mind—I want to sign up for boxing!

She remembers reaching out to catch those sparks—clenching her fists, then loosening her palms, again and again.

Sweat runs through the gaps between her fingers, soaking her palms in scalding heat. Her rising temperature is no illusion.

Spathodea's Mother: Of course, darling.

Her mother's palm gently caresses the little girl's head, coaxing a few raised strands of hair to lie back down.

What follows then is a kiss on her forehead that fuels the warm flames within her arms.

Spathodea's Mother: How about we go pick out some boxing gloves together this weekend? Your dad can drive us… and we can see what kind of protective gear they've got there, too…

Spathodea's Mother: But, starting today, you're not allowed to leave a single vegetable on your plate.

Spathodea: Oh… I thought athletes were allowed to eat triple chocolate-covered caramels and meat pies every day…

Spathodea: But if vegetables are what I need to do to become a real athlete, I'll eat salad every day like a good little kangaroo munching on grass!

The little kangaroo bounces up with gusto and stands proudly on the bedroom floor to declare her intention.

Spathodea: I will be—I must be an excellent boxer!

5#1

Prelude: Clattering Pebbles

COL-308002

Ulu: The closer you get to the light, the clearer things become.

Ulu: Those long, murky roads with no end in sight are far behind me. Now, I'm doing all I can to narrow the distance between her and me.

Ulu: But my light is still too faint… My voice is just a tiny cough, occasionally rising in her throat.

Ulu: For this alone, I'm happy.

Ulu: To see you again, to feel you—to feel that your heartbeat and breath are still out there.

Ulu: Not a single trace of the past seems to show any longer. It all lies somewhere deep within you now, like old clothes waiting forgotten at the bottom of a box.

In the heavy darkness, the flame struggles to flicker onward.

Ulu: I miss you so much, my friend.

Ulu: I want to return to your side, to be before your eyes. I want to see you.

Ulu: Faster, even faster! I need to talk to you face to face …

Street

Sam: Today's training was a bit much,eh? My arms hurt like the blazes… I can barely lift them! I'll have to just plop my face on my plate when I get home to eat!

Sam: Swing training, swing training, and guess what? More swing training! When will it ever end?

The blonde-haired boy bellyaches aloud about his sports class and raises his tennis racket like the blade of a sword.

Two girls walk with him. One seems to be preoccupied with other matters, while the other turns to engage him in conversation.

Mia: Probably next term—next, next term…

Mia: Crikey… What a frightening thought. Luckily, the coach didn't seem to have his eye on me today, otherwise I'd probably be pulling my hair out, too.

Sam: Next term…? Next, next term? Crikey, you've got that right—abandon all hope, I say!

He lets out a heavy sigh and turns his head to look at the other girl.

Sam: Spathodea! Spathodea! Oi, Flammy!

Spathodea: Huh...? Oh! I'm here! What's up?

Sam: How's it all going with you? Coach teach you anything new?

Spathodea: Coach just made us practice our footwork, same as last week.

Spathodea: And apart from that, we've gotta do some resistance band training at home—one set, left and right every day, and then jump rope...

Mia: See, what did I say? Flammy's no bludger, not like someone I know.

The black-haired girl pats her diligent friend's shoulder with pride, imagining she was setting a medal round her neck.

Sam: Wow! You're even doing all the home exercises?!

Spathodea: Well, Coach said I had to...

Mia: What's so strange about that? Flammy obviously wants to move on to the next stage as soon as she can and get some real hands-on experience, right?

Mia: She's not some big lazy couch potato who just lies around eating lamingtons as soon as she gets home, staring at the TV like a zombie, refusing to move a muscle—

Sam: Hey, Mia!

Mia: Nyaaa—! Hahaha!

The girl moves deftly, turning around to make a funny face, then running further ahead.

Spathodea: Wait, Mia!

Sam: You can't just say something like that, then run off! Stop!

The children run off in all directions, a pleasant wind causing the little tumbleweeds to collide and drift apart.

Only one tumbleweed unwittingly falls behind, distracted by the stones on the road.

Ulu: Hey, Flammy! You remember, don't you? You still remember how those funny guys used to pick out small stones on the road, right?

Ulu: Quick! Have a good look and choose the best one—the smoothest one there is!

Spathodea: These stones... They're exactly what we need...

Spathodea: I should pick them up, put them on my knees... to get ready for Malingee.

Finale: Clattering Pebbles

COL-308003

Spathodea: Hey, I got one.

The girl bends down and picks up a pebble from the sand.

Ulu: That's a nice one you've got there! That's the one, Flammy!

Ulu: You can hear my voice, can't you? We haven't seen each other in so long...

The flat pebble burns in her palm. It is a familiar and intimate warmth.

The rustling sound around her ears becoming more distinct as the temperature rises.

Spathodea: I heard the flames calling out my name, just like the ones that were running with me on that field...

Ulu: I'd still run with you if that's what you want! There are so many places we could run to!

Spathodea: She's... She's the flame I should remember... She and I, we...

Sam: Flammy, what are you doing back there all by yourself?

Her friend's voice drowns out the flickering voice, and she regains her senses, clenching the stone in her hand.

Sam: Y'alright? Strewth, you've been in another world all day today...

Spathodea: It's nothing... I'm feeling much better now!

She responds almost instinctively, and to prove her presence of mind, she bends her knee and lays two pebbles flat on it.

They shake for a moment but eventually come to rest.

Sam: Wow! How did you manage to keep them so steady like that? Wait for me, I'll find some pebbles—I wanna give it a try!

Sam: Hey, Mia! Get over here and check out Flammy!

Children's attention shift so easily to such novelties.

Mia and Sam stand around Spathodea, marveling at the pebbles on her knee.

Mia: How do you play? Is it whoever can jump on one leg faster and without falling over wins?

Mia: Or do you need to knock the stone up and then catch it?

If you wanted to introduce those wonderful sports to your friends, now may be the perfect moment.

Spathodea: Yeah, nah, that's not how you play. This game has a name. It's called... Malingee's Harvest.

Spathodea: A long, long time ago, people would compete in a grand event, riding long redwood branches and dancing around a fire with these small stones on their knees.

Spathodea: If the stones dropped, you'd have to go stand at the edge of the field and watch the other contenders compete.

Mia: I get it; it's like a marathon or a track and field race, right?

Spathodea: It's not a running race! Each athlete had to chase the flames with all they've got and try their best to catch them—

She looks left, then right, and then finally fixes her gaze on a leaf above her head, illuminated by the sun.

Spathodea: Three, two ... one!

She leaps into the air and drops back down onto steady feet, with a bright, fleeting flare gathered in the center of her clasped hands.

Spathodea: Just like this!

Sam: Crikey...! How did you do that?!

Sam: You jumped so high and still managed to grab the leaf you were aiming for?

Spathodea: To be honest, I don't rightly know... Maybe it's just one of my special talents? Like running or boxing!

Mia: Flammy's always been good at sports and stuff like that. She even came first in the sprint at our last sports day.

Mia: So... Can you come first in this "Malingee" game? I mean, can anyone win?

Their expectant gazes naturally turn to the girl holding the leaf.

Spathodea: Of course, you can. According to what it says in those storybooks and legends—

Spathodea: Malingee's Harvest can go on for a very long time—it can last one night or even weeks. If everyone's stones fall, then all the players that are watching get to return to the game.

Spathodea: Only when someone grabbed the hottest, most scorching spark from the fire was the game considered over. That's when they found the fire's soul.

Sam: That's so cool!

Sam raises his hands, overwhelmed with excitement.

Sam: We've got plenty of stones right here... Can we play too?

Mia: Play with fire? You drop-kick; your mum would have a fit if she knew you were planning on crawling around in a fire, trying to catch sparks...

Spathodea: Mum says safety is of the utmost importance in all sports... we can't just go jumping around in a fire like the legends...

The child releases the pebble and props up her chin in her dusty little hand as though in deep thought.

Spathodea: Maybe we can change the rules up a little to make it more like a kind of game we can actually play...

Winding water flows across valleys and vast expanses of sand, finally flowing toward another spring.

On the foggy side of the glass, the scorching heat fluctuates.

Spathodea: I remember... I remember... I talked with someone about improving the rules...

Ulu: The skill behind selecting a stone cannot be underestimated! You need to choose the flattest you can find, but you also need to pay attention to the fire—you can't put any thorny shrubs in there as tinder...

Ulu: What do you have in mind, Flammy?

Ulu: Look! So many others want to compete in the Uluru Games with you!

Spathodea: —?

The little girl shakes her head, and the thin, imperceptible flow of water is interrupted once more.

Spathodea: Ahem... I've got it.

Spathodea: Each person chooses two pebbles and places them on one knee.

Spathodea: Then, we'll need to mark the starting and finish line... We can't fly, so we'll have to jump to the end!

Spathodea: We need to agree on which tree we're aiming for first, and then we need to figure out which leaf has the brightest light shining on it.

Spathodea: Then, whoever catches the leaf with the most, the biggest, and the most brilliant light spot is the winner!

Spathodea: What do you think? Any other rules you wanna add?

Spathodea looks at her friends.

Mia: I'm ready for action! Let's get started!

Sam: Hey, I can jump a few steps forward with one leg like this! I'll definitely catch the best patch of light!

The children try it for themselves and quickly grasp the trick of it.

All they need to do now is get into the game and play.

Spathodea: Hah! This branch is even higher! Hey! Who bumped into me?!

Spathodea: Haha… Wait, you two… Don't run away… Hahaha…

Ulu: Needless to say, she won many a victory, time and time again.

Ulu: She's always been good at catching things that flash by and keeping them in her palm.

Ulu: She grabbed those scattered dots of light, just like she once grabbed my fiery skirt.

Ulu: That was the first time we met.

Over the course of two or three days, their walk home becomes an opportunity to share various tips for selecting the best stones and the correct angles for jumping, and soon become engraved wisdom passed to each new player.

A simple yet competitive game always has the power to spread quickly among children.

And along with it spreads a positive and enthusiastic competitive spirit.

Sam: How did Flammy win again today? I've even been practicing in secret!

Spathodea: Heh, that's because I've been imagining this is a real competition! I've been treating each match with one hundred percent seriousness!

Sam: Whatever! Let's play again tomorrow and see what happens! There's no way you can win ten times in a row, or twenty times in a row, or however many times you've won…

Mia: You don't stand a chance, Sam. I've got all the tricks down pat!

The little girl takes a few steps and stands beside the tree, carefully counting the scratches on it.

She then announces the results of the competition in a loud and exaggerated tone.

Mia: One, two… Oh! And still in the top spot is our one and only—Spathodea, our amazing Flammy! She's already won the Malingee championship six times in a row!

Sam: You know everyone's playing your game at school these days, maybe there's already someone better than you out there, Flammy?

Indeed, once someone's competitive spirit is awakened, it is very difficult to put it to rest.

But a burning flame will use anything as fuel.

Spathodea: Bonzer! More skilled athletes means more people to train against, so I can get better even faster!

Spathodea: Doesn't matter whether it's me or anyone else—the champion oughta be someone who abides by the rules and shows off their skill!

Tickets to the pictures from doing the weekly chores, helping the lady next door walk her dog, and saving up for a few months to buy new boxing gloves. After eating up all of her vegetables, her mother kisses her forehead.

These are the things gained through hard work and patience. For this passionate little flame, this is what it means to be a champion.

5#1

Prelude: The Ones Chasing the Flame

COL-308004

Ulu: Clench your fist, swing it, pull it back, swing again. Her arms are sore, but her palms are still burning.

Ulu: I chased after her—watched her practice and practice, spending all her time and energy, making herself burn all over, like a real little flame.

Ulu: Time is like an endless wrinkle—deep, sedate, and difficult to explore, climbing from the cheek to the center.

Ulu: It makes me so happy to see her still so young at heart and full of life.

Ulu: The closer I get to her, the more I feel ablaze.

Ulu: I know I've never truly been extinguished. I've never fallen back into that lightless abyss.

Ulu: But this feeling is different from when I saw her before.

Ulu: Did you pick up those stones because you heard my voice?

Ulu: Do you remember Malingee or the sports game? Are you still you?

Ulu: I think my long slumber is about to finally come to an end.

Boxing gym

Coach: Spathodea, strike faster! Pay attention to where you put your feet!

Spathodea: Okay!

Coach: Keep your distance, don't let your heels hit the ground!

Coach: Keep on your toes and tense your ankles! Throw your fist out!

Spathodea: ...Okay!

Spathodea: Take a deep breath and let your body sink down naturally... Step back with the strike...

Spathodea: Yeah!

Coach: Faster!

Spathodea: Focus... Focus...

Spathodea: Relax... Just grab that spark...

Coach: One-two! Quick!

Spathodea: Same direction...!

Coach: Good, now stop!

Coach: Grab a towel and wipe up that sweat. Have a rest, then come find me by the ring.

Coach: I'm going to check on the others. You alright?

Spathodea: Um... I'm, I'm fine! Thanks!

Wooden benches don't make for the most comfortable seats. But at the club, they're a hot commodity.

After offering a breathless greeting to her peers, she moves her sports bag from the bench and tries to squeeze out a little space for herself.

This is precious break time.

Spathodea: Gotta keep my elbow firm, I let it slip too much, and I took too many steps back...

Spathodea: The footwork and punches—all the key points seem simple enough when you look at them on their own…

She takes out her notebook from her bag and flips to her schedule, checking it carefully.

The page is densely packed with dutifully written training plans accompanied by cutesy doodles.

Spathodea: Where am I gonna find time to do these special exercises…? There's already too much to do…

Spathodea: *sigh* Putting it all together is like trying to do the most difficult homework imaginable! No… it's even harder!

Spathodea: If you wanna dodge, there's no way you can attack, and punching wildly without thinking just leaves you wide open…

Spathodea: …

She extends her left arm, clenches her fist, and swings it toward herself, then promptly lets her fist hover in front of her nose.

After several futile attempts, her hand finally returns to her side and strikes the bench with a sonorous thud.

Spathodea: Woah! If a fist flies in front of your face, of course you're gonna want to dodge it!

Spathodea: Spathodea, Spathodea, be a brave girl wherever you are.

Spathodea: Don't make Coach angry. He has a good enough temper, most of the time, but he's even scarier than a Tasmanian devil when he gets real angry…

A hulking shadow envelops the little girl. Her whispering no longer a secret.

Coach: Oh, a Tassie eh? You think those chattering fur balls are really as scary as I am?

Spathodea: —!

Spathodea: C-Coach! When did you…

Coach: Don't worry, I just wanted to talk to you for a second.

He waves his hand, casting away the noisy marsupials and their childish banter.

Coach: I like to be direct, whether I'm talking to an adult or a child, it doesn't matter. It's good for you to hear the undiluted truth.

Coach: You sure you still want to carry on with boxing?

Spathodea: What…? Of course, I do! You mean I didn't do well at all today, did I? I understand!

Spathodea: I was thinking about it just now—I've been focusing too much on defense, so when I do punch, it's just not strong enough!

Spathodea: I can do better! I'll put in more time…

Coach: Nah, you performed great in today's training.

Spathodea: Huh…?

Her litany of pleas came to a sudden stop.

All the words she had prepared in her mind vanish into thin air, and the expression on her face becomes emptier than her pages of unfinished homework.

Coach: Kids these days are just like Tassies, howling on without even stopping to take a breath…

Coach: Look over there. You ever noticed the photos on the wall behind you?

Spathodea: Of course! That's Gans, and… that's Burns! Patrick, and…

Coach: And this is Spathodea.

His finger points to the end of the line of photos—a blank space waiting to be filled.

Coach: She received… won the golden belt in a big competition.

Spathodea: …!

Coach: I've taught a lot of kids, and very few of them have shown any real talent, but you're up there with the best of them.

Coach: And they certainly can't deal out the kinds of sharp, fast blows you can.

Spathodea: Can I really do it? Could I win a golden belt?

Coach: You've got what it takes, for sure. If you choose to go down this road, you can achieve whatever you set your mind to.

Coach: The problem now is that you gotta make a choice.

Coach: Boxing's a lot of fun, and of course, I know you love it just as much as I do. I don't need to sell you on it.

Coach: But I need to make sure you understand that the things you'll face on this path will be completely unlike anything you've experienced before. Your life as you know it will change forever.

Coach: I'm not just talking about intense training. The expectations on you will be a lot stricter…

Spathodea: I can do it… I'll do anything—

Coach: Nah, don't make a choice like this lightly. You have to think carefully before making a decision.

Coach: I want you to talk it over with your parents.

Spathodea: …I understand.

Finale: The Ones Chasing the Flame

COL-308005

Mia: Keep up, Flammy! We're almost done picking up pebbles!

Mia: Come, I found two really flat ones for you.

Spathodea: …

Spathodea: …Oh! Thank you!

Sam: Did I see Coach chew you out today? Oof… But he lectures me every class; it's not a big deal.

Spathodea: No, not at all. He asked me if I wanted to try becoming a professional boxer. I've been thinking about it non-stop…

Spathodea: I want to say yes, but he said it's a big deal… and I should talk with my parents first.

Sam: Wow! A professional boxer!!!

Just a few words are enough to ignite the children's awe and imagination.

Mia: Flammy, if I bring you a T-shirt tomorrow, think you could sign it for me?

Mia: That way, when you become world champion, I can hang it up in my room!

Sam: Oh, and could you give me your autograph! Wait, gimme three—no, make it ten!

Spathodea: Autograph? Don't be silly—what autograph?! If you really want me to sign something for you, feel free to rip a page out of my homework book!

Sam: Don't get your knickers in a twist! You don't have to do it if you don't want to... You still playing with us today?

The pebble stuffed into her palm by her friend began to heat up slightly.

The weather is perfect for Malingee, with sunlight leaking through the leaves and glittering dust permeating the air.

Take a deep breath and let the warm, fresh air rush into your chest.

Spathodea: *breathes out*

Spathodea: I'm playing! Of course, I'm playing! Just watch, I'm gonna make you all fall in a shower of petals— Ouch!

Fatigue and muscle pain finally catch up with the lively girl.

Mia: Are you alright, Flammy?

Spathodea: Nah, yeah, just got a bit of a muscle ache... I'm fine. When I go home... I'll give myself a massage!

Spathodea: It's pretty common, don't worry... I'll still come first!

The choice she has to make will only be temporarily put on hold, it won't go away.

Sooner or later, she'll have to make a decision.

5#1

Prelude: Beyond the Flame

COL-308006

Ulu: I watched her become a bright flame—from the size of a small stone, swelling to the point where a single palm could no longer hold her.

Ulu: Her flame is constantly changing, its outer glow flickering out an endless dance in an instant.

Ulu: Sometimes, fire can burn too fast, can burn low, and die out. But the embers glow still.

Ulu: Have I managed to get closer to her? Or am I even further away now?

Ulu: I assume my flame is brighter than before. Now I can see clearly the pattern on her clothes ...

Ulu: Flammy still prefers bright colors, and she's just as straightforward and practical as I remember.

She advanced another small step down that path of flames.

Ulu: Soon, I'll need to shake the ash from my body to see if I'm still a bright, burning flame...

Spathodea's Mother: Are you awake, Cookie? Your friends are waiting outside.

Spathodea's Mother: There's some salad and milk on the table. If there's anything else you need, take a look in the fridge. We'll be back later tonight.

Spathodea's Mother: Don't quote me on this, dear, but I don't think professional boxers sleep till noon...

Spathodea: ...

As the sound of her mother's footsteps fade. The child whimpers and rolls over.

Spathodea: ...Hmm.

The cheers of the audience, the praise from her coach, the sweat dripping from her fists… Everything disappears, like those happy memories of dancing over redwood branches, gradually they slip away.

The crowd's cheers turn into prodding calls, crawling into her sore ears from outside her window.

Spathodea: Huh…? Eh?

Stretching out a hand beneath the blanket, she grabs her alarm clock and drags it under. A split second later, she screams and leaps off her bed.

Spathodea: How can that be the time?! Oh no… I said I'd meet up with my friends… I'm late!

Spathodea: Mummy… Did mum come to my room? Was I dreaming? Good grief!

She stumbles and crawls toward the window, opens it with one hand, and pokes her head out.

Spathodea: Wait for me! Please! Just wait a minute—I overslept…

Her friends are downstairs, laughing and horsing around.

Sam: Sleepyhead! Sleepyhead!

Mia: Don't worry, Flammy! We only just got here!

Spathodea: I… I just need to brush my teeth first—

Mia: Flammy, you're usually up early and waiting by the door for us… What's the matter, has the training been wearing you out recently?

Upon hearing her friend's concern, the girl scratches her head awkwardly.

Spathodea: Heh… I fell asleep last night at the dinner table while biting into a sandwich, scared my mum and dad half to death.

Spathodea: But I slept so well! I feel so calm after training, and my hands always feel so warm.

Spathodea: What about you lot? I heard everyone saying a few days ago that they're holding a tennis tournament nearby—

Mia: …

The gentle girl remains silent for a few seconds before averting her gaze.

Mia: Homework and volunteering have kept me busy… I don't think I'll be able to play tennis next season.

Sam: Oi, same here! I'm gonna be working on my survival skills, fishing, and the like, so I can show off next time I go on holiday.

Sam: If I catch anything over ten pounds, those other kids are gonna worship me like a god for the whole year!

Sam: Fancy giving it a try? We could go to the lake this afternoon?

Spathodea: Me? Nah, I've got boxing practice today. Sorry, Sam…

Sam: Oh… Yeah, sorry, I forgot…

They are still friends. They still look the same as they did before. Not one of them has suddenly become "just some kid" to the others.

But still, Spathodea lowers her head and rubs her fingers against the boxing gloves hanging around her waist. But still—

It seems that some kind of change has already begun to take its toll on them.

Finale: Beyond the Flame

COL-308007

Spathodea: *breathes out*

The girl's dinner of stew and pigeon is as delicious as can be, but it still fails to fill her heart.

Spathodea: I had dinner with my mum, saw my friends, and went to training... It's been a pretty full day.

She mumbles to herself, pushing her spine against the door panels. From the gap beneath the door, the light of the corridor melds with the warm yellow of the room.

Spathodea: My friends... have their own lives, and so do I...

Spathodea: I ... stand by my choice still.

Spathodea: Is this really necessary? Can things really change so fast?

Spathodea raises her head and looks toward the ceiling. The soft light of the desk lamp shines on the photo by the window, reflecting a spot of light onto the ceiling.

Spathodea: I'm going to be in a real ring.

Ever so gently, she continues to herself.

Spathodea: The champion gets a belt... a golden belt... It's not pure gold or even gold-plated... It's just golden—

Spathodea: It's a friendly fight, but even so, it's still a golden belt.

It didn't feel so out-of-reach to her as it once was. As long as you jump up high enough, like grabbing at those brilliant leaves, everything is within reach.

But pressure follows close behind.

Spathodea: ...What if I freeze up in front of my opponent?

Spathodea: ...What if I'm not good enough when the time comes?

Spathodea: ...

She switches off the dazzling light and collapses on the bed, her head filled with unanswered questions.

Spathodea: I'm just a kid. I haven't even been in a real boxing ring before.

Ulu: You are the most remarkable priestess there ever was, the best companion there is, and my most important friend!

Spathodea: Will Coach make me stop training if I can't keep up?

Ulu: I trust you, Flammy! I'll do whatever I could to help you, to share my flame with you ...

Spathodea: They said arcanists are physically weaker than most humans. Is that just something I can't fix, even with all the training in the world?

Ulu: Don't be so down on yourself. I've seen how much effort you've put into this! Do you still remember what the whole point of the Uluru Games was in the very beginning?

Spathodea: I remember that voice, echoing with my words among the rocks...

Ulu: Peace, love, justice ...

Spathodea: Mutual assistance, and health.

Spathodea: This is what sports are all about.

It feels suddenly as though a flame is rising up in her stomach.

But in her hesitation it silently subsides.

She turns over, presses her cheek firmly against her fluffy pillow, and closes her eyes.

Spathodea: I'm thinking too much again. These thoughts aren't gonna help me.

Spathodea: I should just sleep early and get up at the crack of dawn… Squeeze in a couple more sets of footwork…

Spathodea: However this ends, all I can do is give it a go and see what happens…!

She endures the burning sensation in her stomach, trying to channel all of her energy into calming herself down, hoping to fall asleep as soon as she possibly can.

Spathodea: Sleep… Sleep…

Spathodea: Sleep… Spathodea…

5#1

Prelude: Within the Palm

COL-308008

Ulu: I saw her tripping over herself as she ran, her flames ready to blaze out of control.

Ulu: All she needs is a little help to get that brightness back.

Ulu: I tried to share some light with her. So we could merge into a sacred flame atop that brilliant platform, just like we did in the past.

The flame persists, spreading onward, advancing in the darkness—almost reaching the feet of the one it's chasing.

Ulu: It's just like Malingee. I have to find a way to get to you… Only this is the first time I've seen it through the eyes of a competitor.

Ulu: Seriously, if we can revive the Uluru Games, we should simplify its rules …

Coach: Are you ready?

Most of the people present simply nod their heads. Scattered echoes of agreement sound from all around.

This is the first time these children will have the chance to experience anything resembling a formal competition.

Even though it is just a friendly competition at their familiar training ground, the exchanging of blows is real.

Spathodea: This is it!

Spathodea: I'm ready to go!

Coach: When you step into the ring, you need to give it your all—don't let everything you've learned so far go to waste.

Coach: In the ring, there's only you and your opponent. Respect the work put in by the person standing across from you.

Coach: But while you're still out of the ring, try to relax a bit.

The coach smiles and gives everyone a light punch, one by one, wishing them good luck. Finally, he punches Spathodea.

Coach: Seize your chance, kid.

Spathodea: ...Thank you.

???: Go get it, little girl.

This encouragement comes unexpectedly from a stranger.

Spathodea: Thank you! I will... Huh? Who are you?

Coach: Liam, you actually came! Keep your eye on this girl here—let me tell you, she's going places —

With this gentle push to both motivate her and urge her on, the little girl leaps out from the rest area.

Coach: Go on. Adjust your breathing, and remember all the exercises we've been doing.

The arena stands before her. The familiar faces of friends, neighbors, and family who came to support her now surround this small square battlefield.

She breathes deeply. Then, exhaling her tension, she calmly crawls through the ropes.

Spathodea: *breathes out*

Spathodea: Let me see... I'm... red.

Ulu: Stay calm, Flammy! Keep your eyes on your opponent—

Spathodea: ...! Push your opponent to the edge of the ring and keep the distance between you as short as possible...

The light bulb above her head radiates a sharply piercing light.

Beneath the tips of her toes, the ring floor is as coarse as earth, and the earth is as red as crimson flames.

One voice, two voices—merged into a wave of cheers.

Spathodea: I've heard cries like this before.

Spathodea: Through brilliant flames rising from the soil—or were they falling?

Spathodea: Don't let yourself get pushed too far away, and don't clench too tightly.

Ulu: Sparks should be observed from an appropriate distance. Listen for their bursts—feel their warmth.

The wind howls in her ears, and the air heats up all around her, rushing to her cheeks.

Opponent: Yeah...!

Coach: ...

Spathodea: Lower your center of gravity, then step to the right—circle around your opponent's side...

Ulu: ...Find an opening, weave through the crowd.

Opponent: Then a hit...!

Spathodea: Step back! Create some distance...

Spathodea: Offense is defense... Raise your arms, protect your chin...

Spathodea: Hyah!

Her blow glances off her opponent's shoulder.

Opponent: Huh?! What was...

Ulu: Don't get distracted, remember your goal—reach out your arm!

Spathodea: It's okay... Just find another chance...

Opponent: Take this!

Spathodea: ...Ugh!

It takes a while for the stinging sensation to rise from her side to the top of her head.

Sweat soaks her hair and fingers. Her surroundings throb and pulsate in the reflection of flickering flames.

The sound of her beating heart drowns out the deafening crowd.

Spathodea: Which spark should I seize?

Mother: Maybe someday soon, your beloved Uluru Games will return. Come on, Cookie!

Ulu: You're the strongest athlete I've ever seen, Flammy! We...

Coach: Spathodea will win that golden belt.

Ulu: Flammy! Eyes front!

Sam: Spathodea!!!

Mia: Come on! Spathodea!!

Crowd: Flammy! Flammy!

Myriad voices twist into a rope, suddenly pulling her up.

Spathodea: *huff, puff* Hah!

Spathodea: Whenever you punch, your strength needs to come from your feet...

Spathodea: Launch, twist your body...

Spathodea: I remember I grabbed at that burning flame just like this.

Spathodea: Straighten your arms and fearlessly throw your fingertips into it.

Spathodea: All in the... same direction!

Audience: Crikey! That little girl's stuck in the corner... She doesn't stand a chance.

Coach: Exactly the opposite.

Opponent: You...!

Opponent: This is boxing, you little runt! You think a pipsqueak like you can...

Ulu: Hah! Flammy's quick enough to find a way out of anything...

Ulu: It's right in front of her!

Opponent: Oof... Urgh!

Crowd: Spathodea! Spathodea!

Coach: I knew that little boost would bag her the win...

Coach: I was right about this one.

Finale: Within the Palm

COL-308009

Slightly prickly fabric, with visible stitch marks at the edges, a gaudy combination of yellow and green.

This was what she won from her junior boxing match. That competition felt more like a high-stakes talent show, with the prize nothing more than a cheap imitation of a real golden belt.

A beloved decoration and a symbol of past glory, it has been with her for a long time. And now, new glories adorn her waist.

Spathodea: Hehe, I've been good to you, haven't I? You're still as beautiful as a pastel painting.

Spathodea: I'll keep you in the little cabinet in my bedroom and come say hi and chat with you once in a while.

Spathodea: Good bye, my old friend.

She arches her fingers and gently touches the textured embroidery.

She folds it in half and smooths out the wrinkles. The second fold turns it into a palm-sized green patch.

Finally, she puts it in her backpack and zips it up.

Coach: A new belt and a new set of gloves. Pretty decent, eh?

Coach: Take it. Towels, water—don't drink too much at once.

The coach nods and handing over the items in his hands.

Spathodea: Ah... Right. Thank you!

Coach: Congrats, kid.

Liam: A prize fit for a champion.

Spathodea: Oh! You're...? In the rest area just now...

Coach: Let me introduce you—this is my old friend. Liam. He works as a boxing trainer assistant and volunteers to help out with the competitions. There's a chance you might see more of each other in the future.

Coach: This plucky little thing's name is Spathodea. She just won the friendlies' championship, so as you can see, she's currently somewhere up on cloud nine.

He pats both of them on the shoulder, one with each hand.

Liam: Haha! Don't mind him, Spathodea. I used to train here too, but it's been a while since I was back.

Liam: Your coach doesn't want us to get complacent—that's why he never has anything nice to say.

Liam: You were great out there, mate! I reckon I'd be hard-pressed to find another amateur at your weight class who could take you on.

Spathodea: Hehe... Does that mean I'm still a long way behind professionals in my weight class?

Coach: I'd say you're only half a pinky finger away.

Coach: But you don't really have any actual in-the-ring experience to speak of. Besides, you're not old enough to join the professional competitions just yet.

Coach: In other words, you still have a final, final chance to make your final decision. You can still choose to turn back.

Spathodea: I'm not giving up! I've already talked it through with my parents!

Spathodea: Plus... I just won my first competition!

Spathodea: I...

The young man had listened with great interest until this moment—as he steals a glance at the clock on the wall.

Liam: Awh, sorry. You two carry on! I've gotta hurry back and clear up the venue.

Liam: I'll be cheering for you, Spathodea! It was really great seeing a fight like that—even if I do end up getting told off, it'll be worth it.

Coach: ... Alright, see ya later.

Liam waves to them, before he walks out of the rest area, a noticeable limp slowing him.

It felt like he left as suddenly as he appeared, vanishing from the door like so many others entering and exiting the boxing club.

Coach: Shame he was in a hurry today; otherwise, he could've told you a bit more about professional boxing.

Coach: So, Spathodea, how does it feel to be a winner?

Spathodea: It feels incredible! Like I could do four more sets of jump rope, three laps around the rings, and a bunch more sets of straight punches...

Coach: Did ya think at any point you were going to lose?

Spathodea: Before I got in the ring, I thought about it for a second...

Spathodea: But there's no time to think about anything else once you get in the ring.

Spathodea: And even if I had lost—sure, I would've been upset, but I'd still tell myself that, as long as I practiced harder and worked on whatever I did wrong...

Spathodea: I'd definitely win next time... or I'd definitely win next, next time!

Coach: But, you know, in the pros, you won't get that many opportunities.

Coach: Everyone remembers the winner, and of course, it's easier for them to qualify for bigger events.

Coach: When you're a pro, your performance in each fight determines your future value.

Coach: Your chances of getting injured are much greater than in an amateur friendly. Some injuries might even end up ruining your career.

Coach: Broken noses, avulsed ears, torn tendons—they're all part and parcel of the sport.

Coach: ...

After a moment of silence, he continues speaking.

Coach: You're a young girl, and you're an arcanist. In the world of sports, you're gonna need to put in a lot more effort than most to prove yourself—there's no getting around that.

Coach: I'm not saying it's fair... but the situation's not likely to change in the short term.

Spathodea: ...

Spathodea: I understand.

Spathodea: After the last time you asked me, I searched around for some information... I... I saw some really, really bad accidents, like... people who got hurt and couldn't box ever again.

Spathodea: Worse than that—some people end up with injuries that change their lives forever.

Spathodea: But I want you to know that I really am mentally prepared for the worst!

Spathodea: Professional boxers don't have very long careers, do they?

Spathodea: So I don't want to waste any time second-guessing myself. The way I see it, every second counts.

Spathodea: I want to carry on boxing, at least for now... I think... I think I can stick with this one thing I'm actually pretty good at.

Coach: You're something else, kid...

He raises his hand and leaves it hovering in the air for a moment before finally patting Spathodea's gloves.

Coach: Glad to see you're keeping your new gloves looking smart.

Spathodea: Hehe... I'm gonna keep the old ones in my backpack for training, since you said it takes time to get used to new gloves...

Coach: Hah, so you were listening! By the way, if you're interested, we're holding a small commercial competition here soon. You can come and join us, if you'd like.

Coach: Of course, you'll be helping out as a volunteer, not fighting in the ring.

Coach: Your next training session won't be easy. Get home early and remember to tell your family the good news.

Spathodea: I'll be off then ... See you tomorrow!

The young flame leaps gracefully through the doorway and bounds away into the distance.

Her boxing gloves swung from her shoulders, their embroidery slightly crooked but dazzling in the sunlight.

The golden pattern sparkling above the name "Spathodea" is sewn below, reflecting its own delicate light.

5#1

Prelude: Sugar and Salt

COL-308010

Ulu: Almost... I've almost got her back now.

Ulu: She will burn within me, and I will make her shine brighter than anything else in the world.

Ulu: We are as close as tinder and flame.

The flame's tongue and the hem of the tiny figure's clothes are now separated by only a fine line.

This long, scorching, flickering road of blazing light is about to reach its end.

Ulu: As soon as we're together again, we'll have a huge, gigantic hug! Then... Then we'll go back to the field together and see what it looks like now!

Ulu: Maybe you'll remember those days rowing the canoe, climbing rocks, or picking silver grass and wild fruit!

Ulu: You just need to bow a little and put your hand in me ... Just like what you did before ...

Spathodea: Oi... move- please... Get out of the way!

Through the twisting jungle of limbs, she finally reaches the entrance to the rest area.

In an environment as hectic as this, it is nearly impossible for a single voice to reach anyone's ears clearly.

Spathodea: Strewth... There are so many more people here than last time...

Spathodea: I... Hey! Sorry, I just need to... get through!

Spathodea: Erm, sorry! Whose foot was that?

Fortunately, her destination is not as far away as she imagined.

Spathodea: Finally— Ah... Just need to open the door...

Spathodea: Hi, I'm helping out with the competition, currently on patrol duty...

Spathodea: Is there anything anyone needs here?

Impatient Competitor: Yeah, you can stop blocking the door. Get out of the way, kid.

Spathodea: O-Okay!

Spathodea: Huh?

As she moves aside, an odd thing seizes her attention. The fighter's bandages were tied too loose.

Spathodea: Excuse me, sir—just a moment… I think your bandage isn't right—

Liam: Hello again, little brawler! Come to see the fight?

Spathodea: Liam!

It was a not-so-unexpected encounter. It seemed like he called out to her purposefully …

Spathodea: Oh, I gotta tell you something about that fighter just now! His bandages—

Liam: Don't worry 'bout it. Come on, sit down over here.

He leads Spathodea to a relatively quiet corner.

Liam: You're a smart kid. Listen, the next time you see something like that, don't go shouting it out loud for everyone to hear.

Liam: Find the right opportunity to point it out to the referee or one of the managers, but don't show a fighter up on the spot.

Spathodea: Huh…?

Spathodea: But the rules say your bandages gotta be wrapped up tightly before the fight starts…

Spathodea: If the referee sees they're not tied according to the regulations, they'll get penalized, won't they?

Liam: See how you remember the rules so perfectly? You reckon that fighter could've possibly forgotten the rules just now?

Spathodea: But when you fight like that, there's a bigger chance of putting your joints at risk! Or getting a fracture…

Spathodea: Why would he do something like that…?

Liam: There are fighters who make a living winning every fight, and there are those who make a living by losing.

Liam: Sometimes there are fighters that will let themselves get beat … they agree to take a fall.

Spathodea: N-No, that's—

That word finds themselves stuck in her throat, cold, thorny, and unwilling to breach the light of day.

Liam: You're right, it's cheating. I know what you're thinking, brawler … Yeah, he's turned his back on the code you'd expect from an athlete.

Liam: But he'll get a guaranteed payoff for it—enough to pay his school fees and the fees for his brothers and sisters, too.

Liam pauses for a moment before continuing.

Liam: You'll come up against all kinds of opponents in money matches. This is just one kind that isn't even worth mentioning.

Liam: Some people fight for their dreams, even if they're the only ones who believe they'll ever come true. Some fight because it's the only choice they have.

Liam: I wonder, what do you think might be going through your mind if you had to stand in the ring with him?

Spathodea: I'd think it's not fair! If I won like that… does that even count as a win?

Liam: So, would you go easy on him? Pull your punches?

Spathodea: I sure would! I wouldn't want to injure the guy...

Liam: Then you might end up being the one who gets hurt.

Spathodea: No... but...

The loose bandage enters her thoughts, and sticks there.

This is a reality that exists outside the rules of the sport. Sometimes things have to go a certain way, sometimes paths change from their original course.

Spathodea: I don't understand...

Liam: Scratches and bruises can heal up with nary a trace.

Liam: But muscle and bone damage can throw a huge spanner into your career.

Liam: An arcanist's strength doesn't lie in their physical ability.

Liam: When he finally recovers and wants to get back in the ring to carry on making a living...

Liam: He'll still be young, but his body might not be able to keep up. His identity as an arcanist will always be hanging over his head like a dark shadow.

Spathodea: ...

The words were like cold fingers, poking their way down her spine, causing her to tremble slightly.

Liam: So he'll be passed over and fall from whatever position he made it to, constantly falling behind.

Liam: At the same time, all the competition prize money and opportunities start to dry up, he has fewer and fewer opportunities to actually fight.

Liam: But it's not often you see this kind of fight-fixing going on in such a small money match.

Spathodea: ...Thank you for teaching me about... this side of things.

Spathodea: Did Coach ask you to tell me about all this?

Liam: Course not! Has hearing all this got you frightened?

He reaches out his hand toward Spathodea with a piece of chocolate in his palm.

Liam: Here, take it. It'll give you a little energy boost when you need it.

Liam: Everyone who's seen you fight is hoping your career will last a long time—that you won't end up faltering on the path to your goal.

Spathodea: ...I'll keep my guard up and take it slow.

Liam: Good to hear. Eat something, cheer yourself up a bit, and go enjoy the fight.

Liam: It's just about choices.

She places the chocolate still wrapped in its brown plastic coating into her pocket.

Where it can accompany a small roll of bandage, a keychain, and a cloth for wiping her gloves.

Spathodea: Wow! Thank you very much...

Spathodea: I'll see you next time then, Liam!

Liam: See you next time, little brawler!

Finale: Sugar and Salt

COL-308011

It takes many times her previous effort to eke out a path through the frenzied crowd.

She can vaguely see the edge of the ring. One of the neutral corners was littered by bags filled with bloodstained cotton balls.

The fight is still underway, and some people are still loudly shouting the title or name of a certain boxer.

Coach: Hey kid, you see Liam?

Spathodea: Huh? Oh! I ran into him just now in the rest area...

Spathodea: Coach, is Liam a big fan of boxing?

Coach: Liam? Course! He loves boxing so much that even after that injury took him out of fighting professionally, he still takes on whatever boxing related jobs he can find.

Spathodea: He used to be a professional boxer...?

Coach: His photo's up there on the gym wall. I thought you'd recognized him.

She scanned the photos one by one. Until she reached the spot right in front of the blank space reserved for her.

An athlete whose last name she couldn't pronounce.

Spathodea: I didn't know he was an arcanist...

Coach: An arcanist? Hah, nah, he's not an arcanist, but he has quite a few friends who are.

Coach: Alright, then—we're not too busy now, go ahead and slack off. Go take a break, if you want.

He gives her flame-embroidered gloves his customary pat.

Coach: Go on, kid.

Spathodea: ...

Spathodea: Think I'll just sit here for a while... Just a little while.

Spathodea: What he said...

Spathodea: It's all so different from the way I thought things were.

Spathodea: Isn't it enough to just follow the rules and focus on fighting with all you've got?

She takes out her old gloves from her backpack, puts them on... and then takes them off.

She finds it relaxing—to slip into something so well-worn and familiar felt like being wrapped in a protective blanket.

She examined the scuffs on the outside leather, remembering how each one got there.

Spathodea: My opponent just now... He bled so much.

Spathodea: It must've been so painful. His family had to be really upset seeing all that.

Ulu: That's right. I still remember that afternoon when you fell over, and we were all on the verge of tears worrying about you...

Spathodea: ...I grazed my elbow pretty badly last time. Mum was so worried...

Her wounds hadn't fazed her, but thinking about her mother's concern makes the little girl feel somewhat guilty.

Her own unanswered cries had never really fazed her, but somehow seeing her dearest friend in tears made the little flame blaze with frustration.

Ulu: You can ask your friends and family, you can ask me, and then you can make a decision you'll be happy with...

Spathodea: It's just a choice. I can make my own decisions.

Spathodea: I already need both hands to count the matches I've won, and I'm the captain of the school boxing team.

Ulu: We'll stand on the playing fields of the Uluru Games once again, Flammy!

Spathodea: Those other things are just distant possibilities.

Ulu: Flammy...?

Spathodea: ...*sobs*

The flame flickers restlessly, as though vanishing and suddenly reappearing.

Tearing open the wrapper and pushing out the sweet contents, the aroma of cocoa lingers in her nose.

For any child, this is the taste of happiness.

Status and money are not things she usually pays much attention to. The ideas introduced to her just now are like a dark slab of frosted glass over once rose-tinted glasses.

Everything has been obscured. She doesn't understand any of this, and the unknown is exactly what scares her.

The chocolate melts against her warm palm.

Spathodea: *sobs* I...

Spathodea: I... want to hear the story of the Uluru Games.

Ulu: Don't be upset, Flammy! We have so many, many stories—you can listen to as many as you'd like!

Ulu: I'll never shout at you again... I'll never argue with you again...

The flame shrinks once again, her flowing tears almost extinguishing her completely.

Spathodea: What am I doing? I shouldn't be sitting here crying like this...

Ulu: No, Flammy...

Ulu: ...

The flame silently goes out.

Spathodea: ...

Now is the time. She nibbles the edges of the chocolate bar, then... she takes another bite, then a bigger one.

The sensation of cocoa and oil sliding over one's tongue proves a boost to her morale.

The subtle saltiness in her mouth doesn't pervert the flavor of the chocolate.

It is still a wonderful treat popular among children her age.

Spathodea: I want to be in there! In that ring ... once more.

Spathodea: Not only for the Uluru Games, but for my next fight's ring, and the next fight...

Tears flow down her face to her neck and into her collar. Seizing the collar, she wipes her tears, smearing them.

Sweat seeps between the lines in her palms and the spaces between her fingers, stinging her sore skin.

Just like after every training session.

5#1

Prelude: Morning Alarm

COL-308012

Ulu: Her tears were like rain.

Ulu: They almost extinguished me completely. She's the one who ignited me… I suppose she should be the one to put me out.

Ulu: But… But I only fell asleep. Just like I've been dormant throughout this unending eternity, I fell asleep again.

Ulu: I've never known such silence before. I can't see anything… My flames can't rip open a sliver of light in the dim night sky surrounding me.

Ulu: Sometimes, I briefly awaken… only to return to the darkness, drifting aimlessly, unsure of which way to go.

Ulu: Flammy! Flammy… can you hear me?

Ulu: Flammy… Spathodea!

Her mad dash finally returned to the starting place.

Ulu: Where did she go?

Ulu: It's too dark in here … Where is she?

She seems to have lost her again.

Perhaps there are no corners to hide in here. All that exists is darkness—endlessly enveloping darkness.

It was a scene identical to one that came before.

On that day, this child, who grew up at the end of the century, first heard the flame's call.

The girl was still sitting at her desk, now with a new album and a stack of photos by her hand.

Struggling with a mess of clay and paint.

Spathodea: …Hmn, that should do it!

Spathodea: Now, let's take a good look at it…

Spathodea: Great! It's almost the same as in the photo! I guess there are still a few bits of rock that need their shape tweaked a little…

Spathodea: Adding a couple more lines to the pattern wouldn't hurt either…

Ulu: Hmm … Huh?

The flame shoots upward for a blazing moment before stopping to take a deep gulp of air.

Ulu: Where is this place?

That was the moment her eyes suddenly opened. She saw the light in the pitch dark.

Spathodea: I'll take it downstairs and show it to Mum and Dad.

Ulu: She's… That girl is… Flammy?

The girl places her creation neatly in the center of the table and prepared to move on to something else.

Ulu: Stop, just for a moment. Just listen to my voice, Flammy—

Ulu: Oh… No… It feels like I'm… going to sleep again…

Spathodea's Mother: We've talked about these paid fights before…

Spathodea's Mother: The importance of safety…

When the fire opens her eyes again, she feels the passage of time hit her at once.

Ulu: Is this… an application form?

Spathodea: Well, I've thought everything through! The date of the competition is…

Spathodea: If I win this fight, all I need to do is… Just…

Sound trickles through as though she were traveling through water—intermittent and accompanied by the small crackling sound of burning flames.

Ulu: Are you still sticking to your guns, Flammy?

Ulu: I can't hear you clearly… Where are you going to fight?

Spathodea: Of course, so I…

Spathodea: Thanks, Mummy! And you too, Dad… I'm going to… training… now!

Her view wobbles as she ascends from the bottom of the stairs. The girl bounds several steps at a time, heading toward her bedroom.

Ulu: Flammy—

Finale: Morning Alarm

COL-308013

The girl reads to her carefully crafted photo album and counts the names and details of each event.

The Uluru Games. Round and smooth, a string of syllables roll around her throat like wild fruit. Reciting these words makes her feel the warmth rising in her palms.

At the same time, it also serves to guide the way for her friend.

Ulu: I finally found the way!

Ulu: I'm back by your side again!

Ulu: You— Oh, what's the matter?

Spathodea: *sob* a little flame? … My head must've taken too much of a beating …

Ulu: Oh no… Don't… Don't be so sad…

Ulu: You're a great athlete and an excellent player!

Ulu: I've been waiting so long to apologize to you. I wish I could take back the things I said the last time we saw each other!

Ulu: I'll give you nothing but praise and compliments. That's all I want to say. I just want you to be happy—

Spathodea: *sobs*… *coughs*

Spathodea: *coughs* Ugh… Waah…!

Ulu: Wait, Flammy!

The flame spreads through her stomach and up her throat, eagerly continuing to surge upward.

Finally, it pushes its way out of her throat, slides across her tongue, and falls into the girl's palm.

There the flame finds its rest and peacefully falls into a gentle, tired dream.

Spathodea: Wh-What—?!

Spathodea: My... My mummy...

Spathodea: She never told me... W-W-We were descendants of the Red Dragon...!

5#1

The Story of You and Me

COL-308014

Ulu: When I finally awakened completely, I told her everything.

Ulu: From unspoken words in the past to words that should be spoken now.

Ulu: We understood each other and exchanged our flames again.

Ulu: A new building has been erected on that red earth, and everything you see around you has changed. Even you are not entirely the old "you" any longer.

Ulu: This sports field has as many eyes cast upon it as before, maybe more. The flames remain as cheerful as ever.

Ulu: It still belongs to the arcanists and mankind together. To those who cheer for the light and flames.

Spathodea: Hah ... Haha... Again we walk on this glorious path together, Ulu!

Spathodea: Ulu! Ulu!

Spathodea: Have I grown up like you wished for me? Am I a new and different me now?

Ulu: My friend! My dear friend!

Ulu: You're my Flammy, but you're so much more than that...

Ulu: You're also my Spathodea... My little girl...!

Ulu: I hope you always run in the free wind, just like we did on the grasslands long again—

Ulu: You've grown up—so far from the age when I knew you so well and from when we were separated—

Ulu: And I... I will always accompany you along your path.

Ulu: Keep that spark in your heart, in your bones, like you once promised—

Ulu: Run, my child!

The gold medal hanging around her neck reflects the flames, each shining brilliantly.

The flames on her gloves, embroidered with her name, reflect Ulu's eyes, glowing with the same radiance.

Just like a championship trophy held high above her head—just like the sweat shed through countless practice sessions.

Just like the blazing flames that covered the Uluru sports field.

Ulu: I once fell asleep and was awakened by the sound of that heart beating.

Ulu: Through her eyes, I saw the world of today—so wide and boundless, it forced my flames to tremble at every turn.

Ulu: Even more distant than the grassland, more vast than the fields of red earth—vast enough for her to run freely.

Ulu: But along the way, I lost touch with her once again.

Ulu: I would awaken briefly to see her talking and laughing with her family or friends.

Ulu: To see her clenching her teeth and swinging her fists during training.

Ulu: And I saw her lost and downhearted, tears pouring over flames and fizzling them into a puff of white smoke.

Ulu: I'm so lucky to see you again!

Ulu: On the field of the Uluru Games, I saw her holding a torch with the medal, the very one she had so long looked forward to, hanging from her neck.

Ulu: I stopped my endless running and returned to her.

Ulu: And she staggered onward, picking up her pace—running toward me.

Ulu: Like two flames merging into one.

Spathodea: Hey, there you are! I couldn't find you anywhere...

Excited cries echo between the rocks and the red earth.

This is where arcanists tread—where they light their torches for Malingee's Harvest.

Mankind also ventures here, raising rackets and bouncing balls into the air.

And here the flame stands opposite the girl who found her.

Ulu: Look. You and I are independent sparks, standing apart from each other again.

Spathodea: I know what you're trying to say, Ulu.

Spathodea: But we can head to the same destination. Two is always better than one.

Spathodea: It's the same as it was in the past.

Spathodea: Come on.

The girl takes off her gloves and spreads her palm wide.

Ulu: Okay, but don't forget—I'm old now, so don't blame me if I nag at you.

Ulu: Just don't fall again—walk carefully around the grass and watch your feet...

Ulu: I think you already know...

The flame leaps into the palm of her hand and lands as lightly as a cat.

She wraps around her five fingers, spreading up to her wrists. It's a perfect fit, well-worn and familiar like her most cherished boxing gloves.

Take another step forward.

Step into the grounds of the Uluru Games. Go back to where you came from. Back to the fire...

Return to that familiar place. The place you belong.

5#2

[English text unavailable]

COL-308015

Spathodea: Hah ... Haha... Again we walk on this glorious path together, Ulu!

Spathodea: Ulu! Ulu!

Spathodea: Have I grown up like you wished for me? Am I a new and different me now?

Ulu: My friend! My dear friend!

Ulu: You're my Flammy, but you're so much more than that…

Ulu: You're also my Spathodea… My little girl…!

Ulu: I hope you always run in the free wind, just like we did on the grasslands long again—

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